

THEFIRST SPARK CHALLENGE

# Pitch Deck Preparation Guide

A self-serve guide to what your pitch deck needs to include — so judges understand who you're helping, what you're solving, and why it matters.

# The Common Pitch Mistake

## ⚠ WEAK PITCH

"We built an AI app that helps with healthcare."

## ✓ STRONGER PITCH

"We help caregivers understand discharge instructions after a hospital visit, so they can manage medication, follow-ups, and warning signs more confidently."

# Pitch Spine

## CHALLENGE STATEMENT

We are responding to: \_\_\_\_\_

## TARGET USER

Our first target user is: \_\_\_\_\_

## SPECIFIC USE CASE

The moment where this problem happens is:

\_\_\_\_\_

## PAIN POINT

The user struggles with: \_\_\_\_\_

## CORE BOTTLENECK

This problem happens because:

\_\_\_\_\_

## CURRENT ALTERNATIVE

Today, they usually solve it by: \_\_\_\_\_

## VALUE PROPOSITION

Our solution helps them: \_\_\_\_\_

## HOW IT WORKS

It works by: \_\_\_\_\_

**One-line output:** We help **[user]** who struggle with **[pain]** during **[use case]** by solving **[bottleneck]** through **[solution]** so they can **[valuable outcome]**.

# Recommended Pitch Deck Flow

01

## **Challenge Statement**

What challenge are you responding to?

02

## **Target User & Use Case**

Who exactly faces this problem, and when?

03

## **Pain Point & Bottleneck**

What is hard, broken, slow, or confusing today?

04

## **Current Alternative**

What do users currently do instead?

05

## **Solution & Value Proposition**

What do you provide, and what outcome improves?

06

## **How It Works**

Show the product flow, workflow, or demo.

07

## **Traction & Validation** — bonus

Any evidence, user feedback, or data that strengthens your pitch.

# Don't Just Name a Target Audience

TOO BROAD

Young women

BETTER

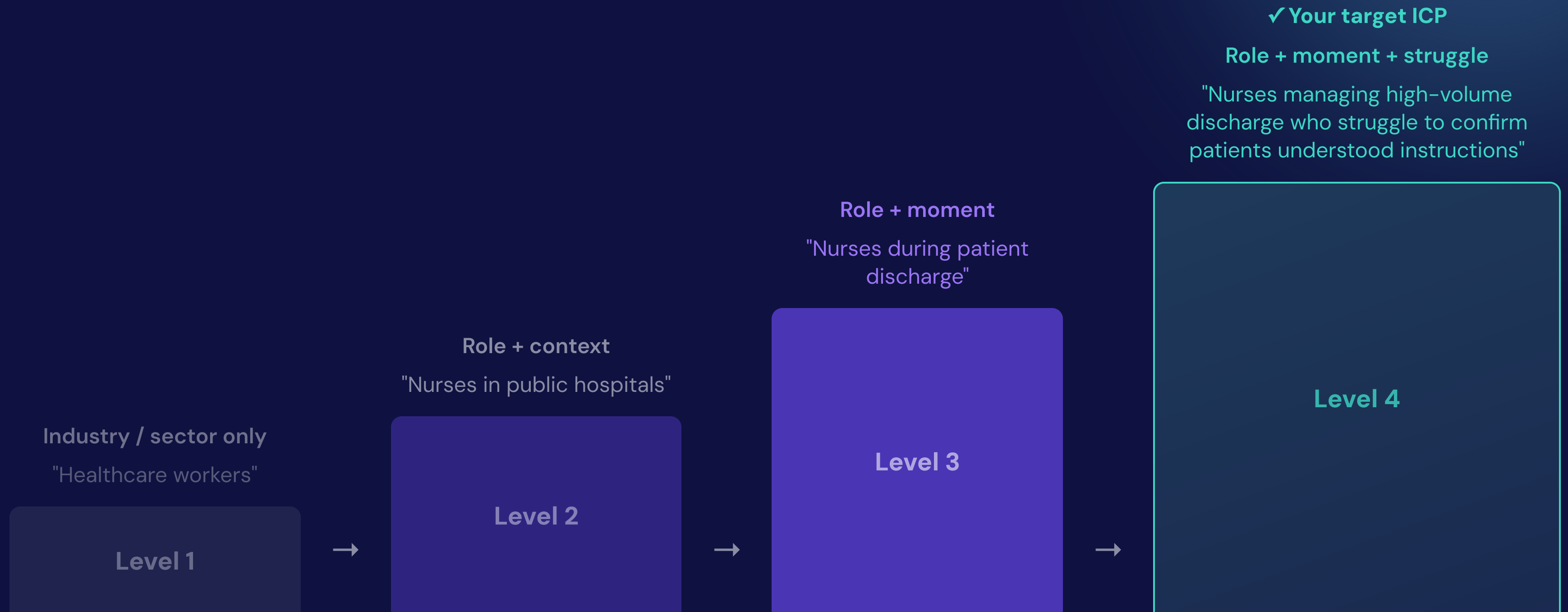
Women in their 20s and early 30s navigating career growth and long-term family planning

BEST

A 27–32-year-old early-to-mid career woman in a high-growth role making major career decisions — promotion, overseas posting, startup opportunity, MBA, or job switch — while quietly wondering how fertility, finances, relationships, and timing may affect her future options.



# The ICP Clarity Ladder



## DEFINITION

# Pain Point

What the user struggles with — the symptom they feel.

## HEALTHCARE EXAMPLE

Caregivers often leave the hospital confused about medication instructions, follow-up appointments, and warning signs to watch for.



## DEFINITION

# Bottleneck

What *stops* them from solving it today — the root cause your solution must attack.

## HEALTHCARE EXAMPLE

Information is given verbally or across multiple documents — caregivers may not know what questions to ask before discharge.

Your solution must attack the bottleneck — not just acknowledge the pain.



# Before You Pitch: Can a Judge Answer...

☐  Who is this for?

☐  What real problem are they facing?

☐  What is the bottleneck?

☐  How does your solution remove that bottleneck?

☐  Why does this meaningfully address the challenge?

If a judge can answer all five, your pitch is **judge-ready**.